

GRANT PROPOSAL

EduMeals Alliance (EMA)

Scaling Sustainable School Feeding to End Classroom Hunger in Kenya

Requested Grant Period: January 2027 – December 2028

Submitted by: EduMeals Alliance (EMA)

Headquarters: Nairobi, Kenya

Founded: 2014 | Founder & CEO: Maurice Juma

Website: edumealsalliance.org

Date of Submission: July 2026

Executive Summary

EduMeals Alliance (EMA) requests a grant of USD 850,000 over a 24-month period to expand and strengthen its regional school feeding operations across Kenya, with a specific focus on scaling delivery infrastructure, field oversight capacity, and data-driven quality assurance in underserved rural counties, including Embu, Wajir, Garissa and Moyale County.

Founded in 2014 with a single kitchen serving a handful of children in a Nairobi informal settlement, EMA has grown into one of Kenya's fastest-growing locally led school feeding organizations, now providing daily subsidized meals to over 15,000 children across a network of central and semi-centralized kitchens. EMA's model pairs subsidized nutritionally balanced meals with technology-enabled logistics, local farmer sourcing, and a co-investment structure in which parents, county governments, and philanthropic partners share the cost of every plate. The organization's stated ambition is to feed 1,000,000 children daily by 2032, and to make the case, county by county, that no Kenyan child should have to learn on an empty stomach.

This proposal requests funding to strengthen the regional operations layer that makes that scale possible: the field-facing Program Analyst and Field Program Officer structure that keeps kitchens compliant, forecasts demand accurately, controls cost per meal (CPM) and resolves facility and delivery issues before they interrupt a child's meal. Grant funds will support staffing, training, data systems, and operational costs across at least three additional rural counties over the grant period, with Embu County as a priority launch site.

15,000+ Children fed daily across Kenya	12M+ Cumulative meals served since 2014	\$0.32–\$0.38 Average cost per subsidized meal
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Statement of Need

The Problem: Classroom Hunger as a Barrier to Learning

Hunger remains one of the most persistent and least visible barriers to learning in Kenyan public schools. National estimates suggest that a significant share of Kenya's children experience food insecurity, with consequences that extend well beyond the school day: impaired cognitive development, irregular attendance, higher dropout rates, and, for girls in particular, increased risk of early domestic responsibility, early marriage, and truncated education. Teachers report that children who arrive hungry struggle to concentrate, retain material, or participate — turning a nutrition gap into a learning gap within a single generation.

Kenya's government has articulated an ambitious national vision — a school meals program reaching 10 million learners by 2030 — but implementation capacity, especially in rural and semi-arid counties, has not kept pace with policy ambition. Many public primary schools, including those in Embu and comparable counties, still lack reliable daily meal provision, safe kitchen infrastructure, or the operational systems needed to run a feeding program at consistent quality and low cost.

Why Operational Capacity Is the Binding Constraint

LBK's experience across more than a decade of scaling shows that the limiting factor for school feeding programs is rarely the willingness of communities or governments to participate — it is operational execution: forecasting meal demand accurately as school populations shift, keeping kitchens stocked and food-safety compliant, controlling cost per meal without compromising nutrition, and resolving the facility and delivery breakdowns that, left unaddressed, cause a program to quietly fail one school at a time. Expanding into new counties without investing in this regional operations layer risks replicating the fragmented, unreliable feeding programs EMA was founded to replace.

Organizational Background

EduMeals Alliance Kenya was founded in 2014 by nutritionist and social entrepreneur Maurice Juma, who began by serving meals to a small group of children from a single makeshift kitchen in a Nairobi informal settlement. Since then, EMA has built a network of urban central kitchens and rural semi-centralized and decentralized kitchens that together prepare and deliver hot, nutritious meals to public primary schools across multiple counties.

EMA's model rests on four pillars: (1) centralized, efficient kitchen infrastructure that lowers the marginal cost of each meal; (2) technology-enabled logistics and a mobile-money payment system that allows parents to contribute affordably toward meal costs; (3) local sourcing from smallholder farmers, many of them women, which strengthens rural economies alongside child nutrition; and (4) co-investment partnerships with county governments and philanthropic funders that make subsidized meals financially sustainable at scale.

The organization has been recognized regionally for this work, including as a grantee of the Pan-African Impact Fund and a recipient of the East Africa Social Impact Award, and has partnered directly with county governments — including a county-level nutrition initiative known as "Meza Yetu" — to co-fund and operationalize school feeding at municipal scale. EMA's long-term goal is to establish an operational blueprint for affordable, locally led school feeding that can be adapted across Kenya and, eventually, the wider region.

Project Description: Regional Operations Strengthening Initiative

Goal

To strengthen EMA's regional operations model — the field infrastructure connecting central kitchens, schools, and communities — so that new and existing counties can sustain reliable, safe, and cost-effective school feeding at scale.

Objectives

- Recruit, train, and deploy Program Analysts and Field Program Officers in at least three additional rural counties, with Embu County as the priority site for year one.
- Achieve and maintain food safety and operational SOP compliance across 100% of kitchens in target regions, verified through regular field visits.
- Reduce stock variance and improve delivery on-time performance to above 95% across supported regions within 18 months.
- Build a regional performance data system that tracks production yield, cost per meal (CPM), delivery adherence, and issue-resolution turnaround, feeding into monthly management reporting.
- Strengthen the capacity of field teams through structured coaching on SOPs, stock control, forecasting, and issue escalation, reducing average facility/equipment issue resolution time.

How the Model Works: The Program Analyst Role

Central to this initiative is the Program Analyst position — a field-facing role that anchors regional accountability. Program Analysts oversee all kitchens within an assigned county, supervise Field Program Officers, and conduct regular site visits to validate that reported performance matches operational reality on the ground. Their responsibilities span four interlocking functions:

- Regional operations management: ensuring every kitchen in the region meets EMA's food safety, staffing, and documentation standards, and engaging school leadership and communities directly to resolve service concerns.

- Forecasting, production, and delivery: leading meal projections based on school calendars and enrollment trends, and coordinating with logistics and procurement so that stock, dispatch, and delivery stay aligned with actual demand.
- Performance, data, and cost control: tracking CPM trends, stock variance, and compliance metrics, and translating field data into clear recommendations for management.
- People capability and facility issue resolution: coaching Field Program Officers, supporting staffing and recruitment, and tracking facility or equipment issues through to resolution within agreed timelines.

Grant funding will directly support the salaries, training, transport, and data tools required to place and sustain this regional oversight structure in newly served counties, ensuring that expansion does not outpace EMA's ability to guarantee quality and safety at every kitchen.

Implementation Plan and Timeline

Phase	Timeline	Key Activities
Phase 1: Mobilization	Months 1–3	Recruit and train Program Analysts and Field Program Officers; conduct county-level needs assessments in Embu and target counties; establish baseline kitchen and school data.
Phase 2: Launch & Kitchen Onboarding	Months 4–8	Onboard kitchens to SOPs and compliance standards; deploy regional data and reporting tools; begin structured field visit cadence.
Phase 3: Scale & Stabilize	Months 9–16	Expand coverage to additional schools; optimize forecasting and delivery routes; roll out coaching program for field teams.
Phase 4: Evaluate & Institutionalize	Months 17–24	Conduct mid-term and final evaluations; document lessons learned; transition high-performing regions to steady-state management; prepare sustainability and co-funding plan with county government.

Monitoring, Evaluation, and Learning

EMA will track progress against the objectives above using a regional performance dashboard populated by Program Analysts and Field Program Officers, reviewed monthly by senior management. Core indicators include: number of children served daily per region, kitchen compliance rate, cost per meal (CPM) and variance from target, on-time delivery rate, stock variance, and average time to resolve escalated facility or food-safety issues.

EMA will also track downstream outcomes consistent with prior program evaluation, including school attendance trends and enrollment change in program schools, drawing on the same monitoring approach the organization has used in its existing counties of operation. An independent mid-term review will be commissioned at month 12, with findings shared with the funder and used to adjust implementation for the remainder of the grant period.

Budget Summary

The table below summarizes the requested 24-month budget of USD 850,000. A detailed line-item budget and budget narrative are available on request.

Budget Category	Year 1 (USD)	Year 2 (USD)	Total (USD)
Field Personnel (Program Analysts, Field Program Officers, Kitchen Supervisors)	165,000	180,000	345,000
Kitchen Equipment & Facility Upgrades	110,000	55,000	165,000
Data Systems, MealLink Technology & Reporting Tools	60,000	30,000	90,000
Training & Capacity Building	45,000	30,000	75,000
Transport & Field Logistics	55,000	55,000	110,000
Monitoring, Evaluation & External Review	20,000	25,000	45,000
Administration & Indirect Costs (6%)	11,000	9,000	20,000
Total	466,000	384,000	850,000

Sustainability

LBK's co-investment model is designed for long-term sustainability rather than sole reliance on grant funding. Parents contribute a small, affordable portion of meal cost through the organization's mobile-money payment system, while county governments are engaged as long-term funding and delivery partners, following the precedent set by EMA's existing county partnerships. Grant funds requested here are front-loaded, catalytic investment in the regional operations infrastructure — staffing, systems, and training — that allows a county program to reach the scale and reliability at which government co-financing becomes viable. By month 24, EMA aims to have secured formal co-funding commitments from at least two of the target county governments, reducing dependence on philanthropic capital for continued operation.

Organizational Capacity

EMA has demonstrated the ability to scale rapidly and responsibly: from a single kitchen in 2014 to a multi-county operation employing thousands of local staff, more than half of them drawn from the communities served, and sourcing from smallholder farmers across its supply chain. The organization has built and operates its own delivery technology, established food-safety and operational standards applied consistently across kitchens, and has a track record of successful co-financing partnerships with county governments. This proposal builds directly on that operating model rather than requiring EMA to develop new capacity from scratch.

Conclusion

Every school day that a child in Embu or a comparable rural county goes without a meal is a day of lost learning that cannot be recovered. EduMeals Alliance Kenya has already proven, at scale, that affordable and reliable school feeding is achievable in Kenya. What stands between the current reach of the program and its 1,000,000-child goal is not vision but operational capacity — the regional teams, data systems, and field infrastructure that keep every kitchen compliant, every

delivery on time, and every plate accounted for. We respectfully request your partnership in funding this next stage of responsible, sustainable growth.

Thank you for your consideration. EMA welcomes the opportunity to discuss this proposal further, host a site visit to an operating kitchen, or provide any additional information your review process requires.

Organization: EduMeals Alliance (EMA)

Website: edumealsalliance.org

Location: Nairobi, Kenya, with regional operations across multiple counties including Embu.